

Minoan Funerary Customs and Practices

Judging by the possessions and objects of value found in those tombs that have not been robbed (jewellery and weapons), and the remains so libations and offerings of food, it appears that the Minoans believed in some form of an afterlife.

They disposed of their dead by burial (inhumation) rather than cremation, the bodies placed in large *pithoi*, or in decorated clay chests called *larnakes*. Some of these were large enough for several burials. The use of *larnakes* became more common over time; however, some bodies were simply laid on wooden biers or beds.

Burials were communal rather than individual, although archaeologists don't know if these group burials comprised of extended families or clans.

Cemetaries or tombs were used over and over again. This was possible because once the flesh was removed from the bones they were discarded, or collected nearly stacked in *ossuaries* or 'bone houses'. It seems that skulls were regarded as sacred objects and the only part of the body worth keeping.

The communal cemetery at Mochlos was one of the largest and most important from the early Bronze Age. Another important cemetery was at Phourni near Arkhanes, but because its burials covered a 1000-year span, it presents a complicated picture.

Different types of burials and tombs:

- Simple inhumation in caves and rock shelters in Early Minoan Period
- Cist tombs - early Minoan box-shaped pits lined with stone
- Rectangular 'house' tombs c. 2600 - 2300 BCE. Like houses, these were built above ground and found mostly in eastern Crete
- *Tholos* tombs (pl. *tholoi*) - first built on the Mesara Plain near Phaistos and common in central and southern Crete although only 70 have been excavated. *Tholoi* were free-standing circular, domed tombs that varied in size from 2.5m to 13m. They were made from rough masonry with roofs of wood and rushes waterproofed with plaster or clay.
- Chamber tombs - cut into the rock of a hillside and were entered via a long, narrow sloping ramp. Chamber tombs were common in the New Palace Period (c. 1700 - 1450 BCE) and then again between c. 1300 - 1100 BCE when they were used for prestigious Mycenaean warriors.



The remains of a Minoan *Tholos* tomb showing the *dromos* (entrance) and its typical domed roof